Conference and the National Conference, the clouds of war in Europe and the growing communal divide in the rest of India, the Raja had only one weapon to use against the enemies of his family—the mobilisation and militarisation of the Muslim subjects of the state. Muslims constituted 90 per cent of Poonch's population; they were ethnically different from the Muslims in the larger Kashmir Valley and also spoke Punjabi. Over 30,000 men from Poonch had served in the Indian Army in WWI; they were enlisted as 'Punjabi *Mussalmans*' and were admitted into the Punjab Regiment. In WWII, over 60,000 men from Poonch served in the Indian Army and formed the nucleus of the revolt against the Maharaja, in 1947.

Raja Jagat Dev Singh feared that Maharaja Hari Singh would leave no stone unturned to completely usurp his power. His only option now was to fan the communal unrest and encourage a revolt by the Muslim population against the Maharaja. However, the Muslim population needed a leader and Raja Jagat Dev Singh thought Muhammad Ibrahim Khan, the son of his carpenter, to be the perfect fit. He sent the young man to Lahore to finish his graduation and then sent him to London to get an LLB. Khan then obtained a Bar-at-Law degree from Lincoln's Inn. Sardar Muhammad Ibrahim Khan thereby became Raja Jagat Dev Singh's agent provocateur against the Maharaja and when he returned to India in 1943, he started his career as a Public Prosecutor in Mirpur.

Unfortunately, Raja Jagat Dev Singh died under mysterious circumstances in 1940 and his wife was prevented from taking control of the *jagir* in the name of their minor son, Ratan Dev Singh. She eventually fled to Nepal with her son and two daughters. The *jagir* came under the direct control of Hari Singh, which obviously agitated Sardar Muhammad Ibrahim Khan, who was then studying in London. He planned to avenge the death of his benefactor and the marginalisation of his benefactor's descendants, and in the process, he also wanted to advance the interests of Poonch's Muslim majority, who would now come under the direct rule of the Maharaja.

Hari Singh, keeping in line with the consistent actions of most of his predecessors against the surviving members of Dhyan Singh's family, had